

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Christmas Eve

24 December 2025 | 11pm



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540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...We extend a warm welcome to all this evening and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

On Christmas Night - SUSSEX CAROL (William Rose) and Improvisation
DIVINUM MYSTERIUM (Improvisation)
Chaconne in G-moll, BWV 1178 (Johann Sebastian Bach)
Toccata, Adagio and Fugue in C Major, BWV 564 (Johann Sebastian Bach)
Proclamation of the Birth of Christ (Christoph Bull)
Scott Graff, *Soloist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

Choral Introit

"On This Day, Earth Shall Ring"
Laude Quartet, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Director*

MELODY 1582 arr. GUSTAV HOLST

Words of Gathering

Rev. Michael Lehman & Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Perhaps for a moment the wheels stop rolling,
the computers desist from computing, and a hush falls over the city.

For an instant, in the stillness, the chiming of the celestial spheres will be heard
as earth hangs poised in the crystalline darkness, and then gracefully tilts.

Let this night be a time when holiness is heard,
and the splendor of living is revealed.

Stunned to stillness by beauty, we remember who we are and why we are here.
There are inexplicable mysteries. We are not alone.

In the universe there moves a Wild One whose gestures
alter earth's axis toward love.

In the immense, sacred darkness, everything spins with joy.
The cosmos enfold us. We are caught in a web of stars,
cradled in a swaying embrace, rocked by this Holy Night,
children of the universe, all.

Let this Christmas be the time we wake to life,
like spring wakes, in the moment of sacred turning, and welcomes the light.
-adapted from Rebecca Anne Parker's *Winter Solstice*

Please stand, in body or in spirit, for our Christmas Eve Hymn of Gathering

Christmas Eve Hymn of Gathering *O Come, All Ye Faithful

***O Come, All Ye Faithful**, joyful and triumphant,
O come ye, O come ye, to Bethlehem.
Come and behold the ruler of all angels:
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

God of true God, Light of true light,
born of the Virgin's womb in human form;
Truly our God, begotten, not created:
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

Sing, choirs of angels, sing in exultation,
sing, all you messengers of heavenly love:
'Glory to God, all glory in the highest':
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

Yes, Lord, we greet thee, born for our salvation,
Jesus, to you shall all glory be given;
Word of our God... now in flesh appearing;
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Holy One, in this moment in time, the sounds of joy and elation
fill our hearts with anticipation and appreciation
for all the ways you are always and forever
present in and through our lives, God-with-us.

In this moment in time, it is also the silence
that whispers joy into our lives.

We breathe deeply of its gifts.

Silence

Tonight, in this sacred space, may the comfort of familiar carols,
filled with notes of hope, dispel the despair that envelops us.

Tonight, in familiar words spoken and sung anew,
illumine us with the grace that is born into our lives,
and of the peace which is birthed amid our shadowed fears.

Tonight, O God, as we lean in close to those
who have always been a part of us, and those from whom we have been apart,
remind us of your heart, which always finds room for us,
and welcomes us, just as we are.

*Tonight, in the depths of the love which is ours forever,
draw us near to your heart as we open wide our own.
May we be surprised again by wonder, swaddled in serenity
and sacred mystery, and embraced by tenderness.*

Then, O God, touch us again with Christmas.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Lighting of the Christ Candle

Christoph Bull

Hope, peace, joy, and love: four candles, four promises continually offered us by the Holy. All of them gather their lights in the one we light tonight: the Christ Candle.

In Jesus is the hope of transformation, the peace that follows justice, the joy of fulfillment in community, and the love that encompasses us in all our diversity, empowering us to make our own unique contributions to this world in love and light.

Musical Response

"Brightest and Best"

arr. MATTEA AND MAHER

Laude Quartet, Ianthe Marini, *flute*, Michael Lehman, *percussion*, Christoph Bull, *Organ*

The Light

Isaiah 9.2-7

Scott Graff and Ianthe Marini

The Light... from Isaiah chapter 9...

The people walking in darkness
are seeing a brilliant light –
upon those who dwell
in a land of deep shadows
light is shining!

For a child is born to us,
an heir is given us,
upon whose shoulders
dominion will rest.

This one shall be called
wonderful counselor,
the strength of God,
Eternal Protector,
Champion of Peace.

This dominion, and this peace,
will grow without end,
with David's throne and realm
sustained with justice and fairness,
now and forever.

The zeal of YHWH Omnipotent
will accomplish it!

—

I cannot tell you how the light comes.
What I know is that it is more ancient than imagining.
That it travels across an astounding expanse to reach us.
That it loves searching out what is hidden, what is lost,
what is forgotten or in peril or in pain.
That it has a fondness for the body,
for finding its way toward flesh, or tracing the edges of form,
for shining forth through the eye, the hand, the heart.

I cannot tell you how the light comes, but that it does. That it will.
That it works its way into the deepest shadows that enfolds us,
though it may seem long ages in coming or arrive in a shape we did not foresee.

And so may we this night turn ourselves toward it.
May we lift our faces to let it find us.
May we bend our bodies to follow the arc it makes.
May we open and open more and open still
to the blessed light that comes.

—Jan Richardson, *Circle of Grace: A Book of Blessings for the Seasons*

Musical Response

“‘Twas in the Moon of Wintertime”
Laude Quartet

TRADITIONAL HURON CAROL
arr. ROBIN JOHN KING

The Promise

Luke 1:26-32

Tiffany Ho and Ianthe Marini

The Promise...from Luke chapter 1...

The Angel Gabriel was sent from God
to a town in Galilee called Nazareth,
to a young woman named Mary;
she was engaged to a man named Joseph,
of the House of David.
Upon arriving the angel said to Mary,
‘Rejoice, highly favored one!
God is with you! Blessed are you among women!’

Mary was deeply troubled by these words
and wondered what the angel’s greeting meant.
The angel went on to say to her,
‘Don’t be afraid, Mary.
You have found favor with God.
You will conceive and bear a son,
and give him the name Jesus –
which means deliverance.
His dignity will be great and he will be called,
the only begotten of God.

Mary said to the angel,
“How can this be, since I have never been with a man?”
The angel answered her,
“The Holy Spirit will come upon you,
and the power of the Most High will overshadow you—
hence the offspring to be born will be called the Holy One of God.
Know, too, that Elizabeth, your kinswoman, has conceived a child in her old age;
she who was thought to be infertile is now in her sixth month.
Nothing will be impossible with God.”
Mary said, “I am the servant of God.
Let it be done to me as you say.”
With that, the angel left her.

—
This blessing is for the moment after clarity has come,
after inspiration, after *you* have agreed to what seems impossible.
This blessing is what follows after illumination departs
and you realize there is no map for the path you have chosen,
nothing to do but gather up your gumption and set out.

This blessing will go with you.
It carries no answers, no charts, no plans.
It carries no source of light within itself.
But in its pocket is tucked a mirror that, from time to time,
it will hold up to you to remind you of the radiance that came
when you gave your awful and wondrous *yes*.

—Jan Richardson, *Circle of Grace: A Book of Blessings for the Seasons*

Musical Response

“I Wonder as I Wander”
Tiffany Ho, *Soprano*, Ianthe Marini, *flute*

arr. BENJAMIN BRITTEN

The Journey

Luke 2:1-7

Scott Graff

The Journey...from Luke chapter 2...

In those days, Caesar Augustus published a decree
ordering a census of the whole Roman world.
This first census took place while Quirinius
was governor of Syria.

All people were instructed to go back
to the towns of their birth to register.
And so Joseph went from the town of Nazareth in Galilee
to the City of David – Bethlehem, in Judea,
because Joseph was of the house and lineage of David;
he went there to register with Mary, his espoused wife,
who was pregnant.

While they were there, the time came for her delivery.
And she gave birth to her firstborn, a son;
she wrapped in swaddling cloth and laid him in a manger,
because there was no room for them at the inn.

And in these days a decree goes out to all the world, for these are taxing times.
 We are all called again to Bethlehem, no matter the state or our world.
 We come, weary and faithful, for we have heard the message,
 we have dreamed the dream that God will come to dwell among us.
 We come, expectant with joy, pregnant with anticipation,
 for God has done great things for us.
 We come searching for a sign; bearing our gifts, we come.
 We come, called from the silent hillsides of our hearts,
 startled and frightened by the magnitude of light,
 we huddle together toward Bethlehem.
 We come, one by one, and yet, as one, dancing into the Journey.

—Ann Weems, *Kneeling in Bethlehem*

Musical Response

“Lullay My Liking” and “Lullay, Lully” GUSTAV HOLST & WALFORD DAVIES
 Scott Graff, *soloist*, Laude Quartet

The Shepherds & Angels

Luke 2:8-12

Quartet

“And there were shepherds” and “Glory to God,” from *Messiah*
 Ianthe Marini, *Soloist*, Laude Quartet, Christoph Bull, *Piano*

The Good News

Luke 2:13-20

Christin Byrdsong

The Good News...from Luke chapter 2...

When the Angels had returned to heaven,
 the shepherds said to one another,
 ‘Let us go straight to Bethlehem and see
 this event God has made known to us.’

They hurried and found Mary and Joseph,
 and the baby lying in the manger.
 Once they saw this, they reported what they
 had been told concerning the child.
 All who heard about it were astonished
 at the report given by the shepherds.

Mary treasured all these things
 and reflected on them in her heart.
 The shepherds went away glorifying
 and praising God for all they had heard and seen,
 just as they had been told.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Musical Response

“O, Holy Night”
 Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*, Christoph Bull, *Organ*

ADOLPHE ADAM

Prayer for Christmas Eve

Rev. Lehman

Holy One of Promise,
through the long, candle-lit weeks that have led us to the glory of this night,
we have whispered the old question,
"What do we truly long for this Christmas?"

Tonight, beneath a sky trembling with wings and song,
we are given what we did not know how to ask for:
the grace to kneel again in Bethlehem,
where the very air shimmers with alleluias
and angels lean close to earth,
singing that the Holy is born among us again.

And the gifts we carry into the world
are open, overflowing hearts,
ready to become
all Now, by the soft, unwavering light of the Star, we come;
we, who so often stumble in our wisdom
and shy from humility.
We come carrying whatever treasure our hearts can offer,
placing it beside the cradle
of the One who breathes life and love into the world.

What gift can we offer in reply?
With eyes widened by wonder
and ears tuned to the rustle of heaven and earth intertwined,
we offer the gift of our remade hearts,
the promise of lives opened
to the newborn light within us.
For the mystery of this night,
the Nativity of all nativities,
belongs to each and every one of us.

We are the Beloved of God,
we were dreamt and shaped to be,
in this sacred moment,
in this our time and place.

Amen and Amen!

Let us stand now, in body or in spirit, and sing our joy together!

*Music of the People

Go Tell it on the Mountain

Refrain Go tell it on the mountain, Over the hills and everywhere
Go tell it on the mountain that Jesus Christ is born.

While shepherds kept their watching o'er silent flocks by night
Behold throughout the heavens there shone a heavenly light:

Refrain

The shepherds feared and trembled When lo! Above the Earth
Rang out the angel chorus that hailed our Savior's birth!

Refrain

Down in a lowly manger our humble Christ was born
And brought us all salvation that blessed Christmas morn!

Refrain

Angels We Have Heard on High

Angels we have heard on high sweetly singing o'er the plains,
And the mountains in reply echoing their joyous strains!

Refrain

Gloria, in excelsis Deo!

Gloria, in excelsis Deo!

Shepherds, why this Jubilee? Why your joyous strains prolong?
What the gladsome tidings be, which inspire your heavenly song?

Refrain

Come to Bethlehem and see Christ whose birth the angels sing.
Come, adore on bended knee, Christ the Lord, the newborn King!

Refrain

Please be seated

Invitation to Generosity - Christmas Eve Offering

Rev. Fregin

Offertory

"Sing We Now of Christmas"
and Improvisation on the Carol with Dr. Christoph Bull
Laude Quartet, Christoph Bull, *Organ*

arr. FRED PRENTICE

***Offering Response**

The First Noel

The first Noël the angel did say
was to certain poor shepherds in fields as they lay,
in fields where they lay keeping their sheep,
on a cold winter's night that was so deep.

Refrain

Noël, Noël, Noël, Noël,
Jesus is born, let us sing Noël.

***Offering Prayer**

Rev. Fregin

May the God of Silent Nights be with us!
May the God of Herald Angels be with us!
May the God of Faithful Shepherds be with us!
May the God of open hearts be with us,
as we share these gifts with hope,
peace, joy, and love.

*In the days to come,
may our voices blend with those of the angels and shepherds,
as we work together for justice and peace in our lives,
in our city, and in our world.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please be seated

The Eucharist & Blessings

Reflection & Invitation

Rev. Lehman

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This night, we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts by way of the center aisle, and then return to your seat via the side aisles. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Communion Musical Offering

"Wexford Carol"

arr. CHARLES FLOYD AND YO-YO MA

Laude Quartet, Christoph Bull, *Organ*, Ianthe Marini, *flute*

The Beginning

John 1

Rev. Fregin

The Beginning...from John chapter 1...

In the beginning there was the Word;
the Word was in God's presence,
and the Word was God.
The Word was present to God
from the beginning.

Through the Word
all things came into being,
and apart from the Word
nothing came into being
that has come into being.

In the Word was life,
and that life was humanity's light –
a light that shines in the night,
a Light that the shadows have
never overtaken.

***Music of the Night**

Silent Night

STILLE NACHT

Silent night, holy night,
All is calm, all is bright
Round yon virgin mother and child.
Holy infant, so tender and mild,
Sleep in heavenly peace,
Sleep in heavenly peace.

Silent night, holy night,
Shepherds quake at the sight;
Glories stream from heaven afar,
Heavenly hosts sing Alleluia!
Christ the Savior is born,
Christ the Savior is born!

Silent night, holy night,
Son of God, love's pure light;
Radiant beams from thy holy face
With the dawn of redeeming grace,
Jesus, Lord, at thy birth,
Jesus, Lord, at thy birth.

***Christmas Blessing for the Journey**

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Blessed are you who bear the light in unbearable times,
who testify to its endurance amid the unendurable,
who bear witness to its persistence when everything seems in shadow and grief.

Blessed are you in whom the light lives,
in whom the brightness blazes— your heart a chapel,
an altar where in the deepest night can be seen the fire that shines
forth in you in unaccountable faith, in stubborn hope,
in love that illumines every broken thing it finds.

—Jan Richardson, *Circle of Grace: A Book of Blessings for the Seasons*

May it forever be so.

May it forever be so for all of us!

Amen and amen!

***Christmas Hymn for the Journey**

Joy to the World

Joy to the world! The Christ is here!
The gift of peace to bring!
Let ev'ry heart a welcome place prepare.
And heav'n and nature sing,
And heav'n and nature sing,
And heav'n, and heav'n and nature sing!

Joy to the earth! The Savior lives!
With song your voice employ;
While fields and floods, rock, plains and hills
Repeat the sounding joy,

Repeat the sounding joy,
Repeat, repeat the sounding joy!

Christ fills the world with truth and grace,
And asks each life to prove
The glories of God's righteousness
And wonders of God's love,
And wonders of God's love,
And wonders, and wonders of God's love! *GPHaddon*

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-In-Residence*

Toccata in C Major - Reprise, BWV 564/1 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

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